

city?” and the technology flails. What’s interesting about this class of queries is that they are relatively easy for a person to answer. Imagine being at a cocktail party surrounded by friends. How likely would you be to get a high-quality answer to your subjective question? You almost certainly would get one. Unlike factual queries, because these subjective questions have no single right answer, today’s technology struggles to answer them. Such questions depend on the person answering them, his or her personal experience, taste, and assessment of what you’re looking for.

To solve this problem, Max and Damon created a product called Aardvark. With their deep technical knowledge and industry experience, it would have been reasonable to expect them to dive in and start programming. Instead, they took six months to figure out what they should be building. But they didn’t spend that year at the whiteboard strategizing or engage in a lengthy market research project.

Instead, they built a series of functioning products, each designed to test a way of solving this problem for their customers. Each product was then offered to beta testers, whose behavior was used to validate or refute each specific hypothesis (see examples in sidebar).

The following list of projects are examples from Aardvark’s ideation period.⁷

Rekkit. A service to collect your ratings from across the web and give better recommendations to you.

Ninjapa. A way that you could open accounts in various applications through a single website and manage your data across multiple sites.